



Tower of London

William the Conqueror's Norman fortress, royal palace, notorious prison, and treasury of the British monarchs



△ COMPLEX CASTLE

Inside the curtain walls, the White Tower dominates the complex. Behind it is the Waterloo Block, home to the Crown Jewels. Traitor's Gate (bottom) leads up from the Thames to the Bloody Tower just behind.

In 1066, William the Conqueror took the English crown at the Battle of Hastings. As part of the ongoing conquest of England, he built a series of castles from which his Norman followers could dominate the country. The most impressive was the fortress built on the banks of the River Thames in London. At the heart of this fortress was a solid, square keep, known from the 13th century as the White Tower after it was whitewashed on the orders of King Henry III. Constructed in stone brought from Caen, France, between c.1078 and 1100, the massive tower measured 118 by 107 ft (36 by 33 m). It had walls that were 15 ft (4.6 m) thick at the base, and it rose to a height of 90 ft (27.5 m). The Tower of London was three times as tall as its neighbors and gave its name to the whole castle complex. Dominating the landscape—it was the first structure seen when arriving in London by boat—it served as a potent reminder of the city's defeat to the Norman invaders.

Strengthened fortifications

In the 13th century, Henry III and Edward I expanded William's fortress with the addition of concentric rings of "curtain walls" (defensive walls) and towers, a moat, and the Traitor's Gate. Among the additions was the infamous Bloody Tower, where Henry VI was murdered in 1471 and where Edward IV's two sons disappeared, perhaps killed, in 1483. Later monarchs added more buildings to the Tower. In 1826, the Constable of the Tower, the Duke of Wellington, began modernizing the site, draining the moat and closing the Royal Menagerie, created by King John in the 13th century and once home to lions, bears, and elephants. Witness to battles and beheadings, the Tower has served as a prison, a royal residence, home to the Royal Mint, and an armory, and has been the repository of Britain's priceless Crown Jewels since 1600.

CONCENTRIC CASTLES

The White Tower was the earliest of the large rectangular stone keeps in England. Thereafter, many wooden castles erected in the years of the Conquest were then rebuilt in stone. Some were fortified in the 12th and 13th centuries by the addition of encircling walls. The Tower of London was one of the largest and strongest of these "concentric" castles in England.

